

Partisan vs Climate Cues and Public Opinion about Trump's Actions on Energy

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Motivation

What shapes public support for President Trump's actions on energy?

- The second Trump administration has moved aggressively to promote fossil fuels and sideline renewable sources
- Historically, energy opinion was about cost and availability, not partisanship ([Ansolabehere and Konisky 2016](#))
- Energy has become more polarized in recent years, likely through its connection to climate change
- Trump's actions may polarize opinion further — but through **Trump himself**, or through **climate change**?

Trump's Actions on Energy

In the first year of his second term, the administration:

- Limited the eligibility of wind and solar projects for federal tax credits ([Spring 2025](#))
- Required coal plants set to retire to remain open ([Thakore and Brasch · 2025](#))
- Opened 13.1 million acres of federal land for coal leasing ([US Department of Interior" 2025](#))
- Cancelled a nearly complete offshore wind project ([Trump Administration Pauses Offshore Wind Projects Along the East Coast 2025](#))
- Shortened the licensing timeline for new nuclear power plants ("[Trump's Licensing Goals Pile Pressure on Nuclear Regulator" 2025](#); [US Department of Energy" 2025](#))

Polarization on Energy Is Uneven

Baseline partisan polarization differs across energy sources

- **Fossil fuels (coal):** the deepest partisan split of any source (Hart, Stedman, and Clarke 2021)
- **Wind and solar:** majorities across parties favor expansion; partisans disagree over *how much*, not *whether* (Bergquist, Konisky, and Kotcher 2020; Hamilton et al. 2018)
- **Nuclear:** modestly more support on the right, but no sharp split (McBeth, Warnement Wrobel, and van Woerden 2023; Yeo et al. 2014)
- Republicans and Democrats also support renewables for *different reasons* — costs and energy security vs. climate change (Gustafson et al. 2020)

Cues and Cue-Taking

- Partisan cues are a heuristic: citizens infer their own position from the position of their party's elites (Kam 2005; Schaffner and Streb 2002)
- Best understood through motivated reasoning — processing information to protect prior partisan commitments (Druckman, Peterson, and Slothuus 2013; Taber and Lodge 2006)
- On energy and climate, attaching a climate frame or a Democratic-source cue is often enough to depress Republican support (Feldman and Hart 2018; Merkley and Stecula 2021)

A Trump Cue Is Distinct

- Individual elites, not parties in the abstract, tend to carry the most weight (Brulle, Carmichael, and Jenkins 2012; Nicholson 2012)
- Trump specifically has moved opinion on immigration and trade — a documented “Trump effect” (Essig et al. 2021; Taylor 2026)
- His administration has taken concrete steps to expand fossil fuels and curb renewables (Gerrard 2025), so the same dynamic is likely to carry over to energy
- **Channel 1:** a Trump cue activates expressive, cue-receptive partisanship; a climate cue taps the substantive climate concern that already divides the parties

Does Education Matter?

- Low-information account: less-educated citizens rely on party cues the most (Kam 2005; Mérola and Hitt 2016)
- But education can also enable *more effective* motivated reasoning (Bakker, Lelkes, and Malka 2019; Kahan 2013) and has *amplified* climate polarization among conservatives (Hamilton 2011)
- Trump's strength among non-college white voters — the “diploma divide” (Morgan and Lee 2018; Zingher 2022)
- **Channel 2:** if the Trump cue draws on identity-based appeal, its effects should concentrate among non-college partisans

Hypotheses

Two channels: partisan cue-taking and education

H1: *Conservative Republicans who receive the Trump or climate cue will be **more** supportive of Trump's actions than others*

H2: *Liberal Democrats who receive the Trump or climate cue will be **less** supportive than others*

H3: *Conservative Republicans **without a college degree** who receive the Trump cue will be more supportive than others*

H4: *Liberal Democrats **without a college degree** who receive the Trump cue will be less supportive than others*

Data and Analysis

Survey

- Quota-based sample of US residents recruited through *Cloud Research*
 - Quotas from US Census data for age, gender, and race
- Internet-based, administered in QuestionPro
- Fielded April 10–15, 2026
- $N = 3113$
- Iterative raking ([survey](#), [anesrake](#)) to the 2023 ACS on age, race, gender, and education; Pew NPORS 2025 for party affiliation

Experimental Design

Respondents randomly assigned to one of three conditions:

- **Trump cue** ($n = 1049$) — actions attributed to the *Trump Administration*
- **Climate cue** ($n = 1013$) — actions attributed to the *federal government*, plus a statement that scientists are concerned the actions could make climate change worse
- **Control** ($n = 1051$) — actions attributed to the *federal government*, no cue

Question Wording

Recently, the [*Trump Administration / Federal government*] took several actions to shape electricity generation in the U.S.

Climate cue: *Scientists are concerned that the actions associated with coal, wind, and solar energy will make climate change worse.*

Using a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 means strongly oppose and 5 means strongly support, how do you feel about the following actions of the [*Trump Administration / Federal government*]? [*items randomized*]

Measures

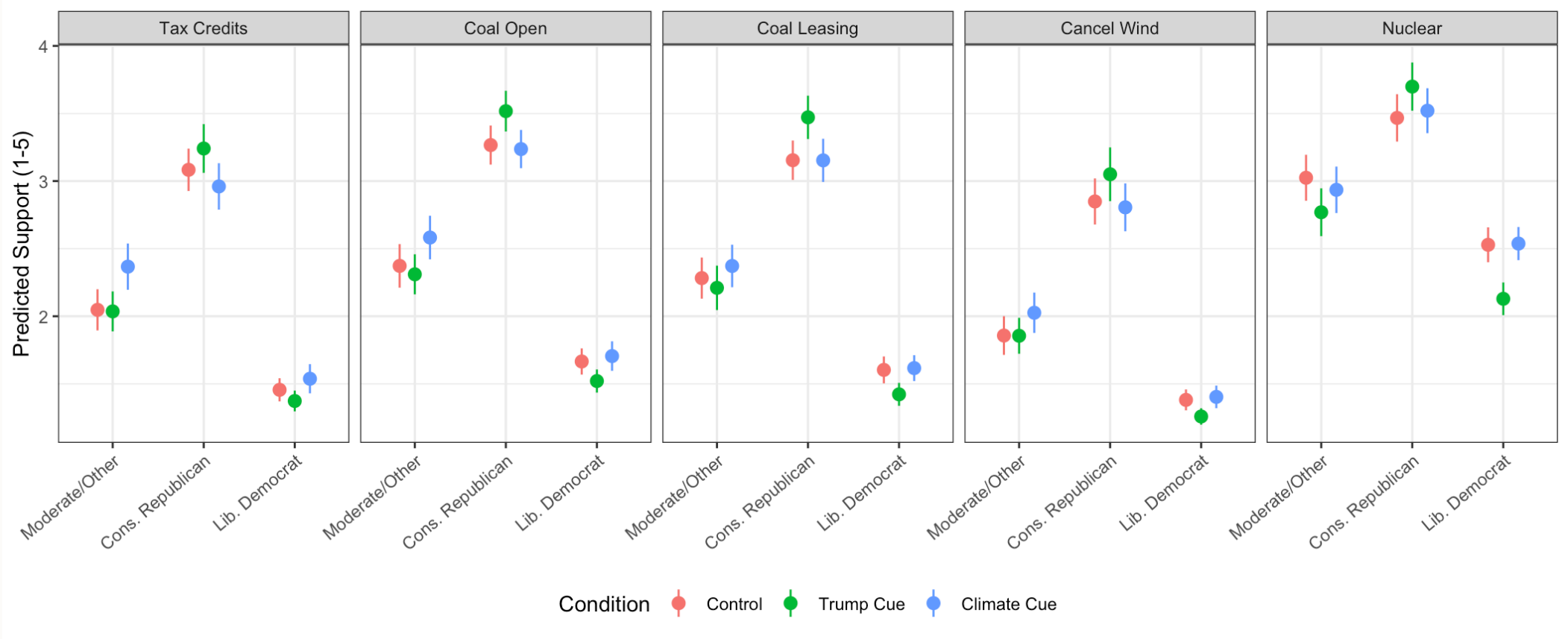
- **Dependent variables:** support (1–5) for each of the five actions
 - Tax credits, coal open, coal leasing, cancel wind, nuclear licensing
- **Political beliefs:** conservative Republican, liberal Democrat
 - Moderate/other (moderate independents, cross-pressured partisans) is the excluded referent
- **College:** 1 = completed a college degree, 0 = did not

Model

- Survey-weighted OLS (`svyglm`), one model per action
- Cue main effects, political beliefs, and college
- Interactions:
 - cue × political beliefs → H1, H2
 - Trump cue × beliefs × college → H3, H4
- Reference categories: control condition, moderate/other identity, no college degree

Results

Predicted Support by Cue and Political Beliefs



Predicted Support by Cue and Political Beliefs

Conservative Republicans

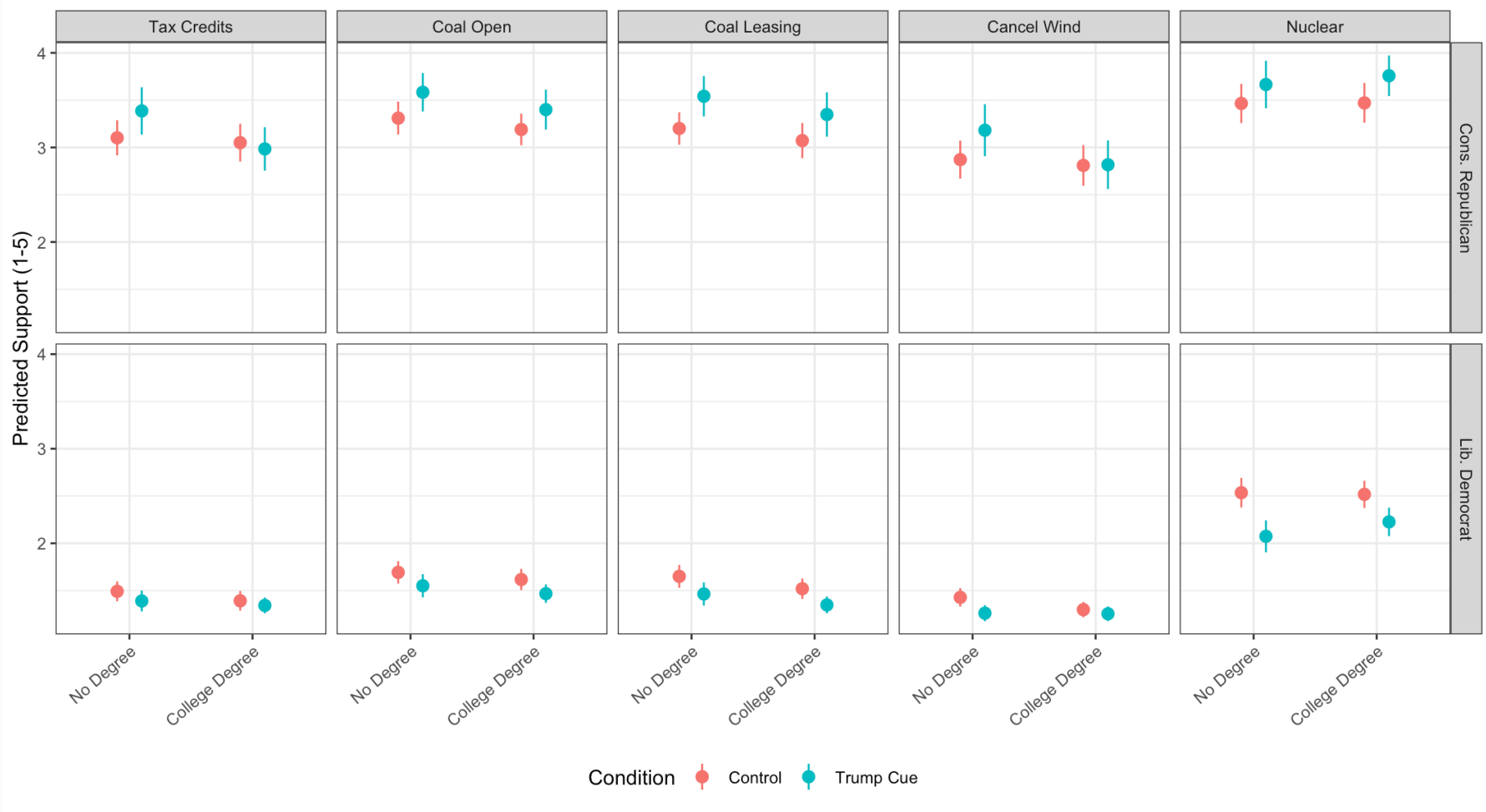
- Trump cue significantly *increased* support for opening federal lands to coal leasing and for shortening nuclear licensing
 - Increases for keeping coal plants open and cancelling the offshore wind project at $p < 0.10$
- Trump cue did **not** move support for eliminating wind and solar tax credits
- Climate cue *decreased* support for eliminating tax credits

Predicted Support by Cue and Political Beliefs

Liberal Democrats

- Largely unresponsive to both the Trump cue and the climate cue
- Reduction in support for eliminating tax credits under the climate cue ($p < 0.10$)
- Likely a floor effect — opposition to coal leasing and tax credit elimination was already near the bottom of the scale in the control condition

Predicted Support by Trump Cue and College Degree



Education Did Not Moderate the Cues

- No differences across the three-way interaction of Trump cue x college x political beliefs
- Non-college respondents were **no more** responsive to the Trump cue than college respondents — for both Republicans and Democrats (H3, H4 unsupported)
- But education *independently* conditions support among committed partisans:
 - College-educated conservative Republicans **and** liberal Democrats were *less* supportive of cancelling wind projects and shortening nuclear licensing than their non-college co-partisans
 - The opposite pattern holds among moderate/other respondents

Discussion

- The **Trump cue**, not the climate cue, moved opinion — and only among conservative Republicans (H1 partly supported)
- No Trump cue effect on eliminating tax credits — the only action that *cuts* an existing renewable program rather than expanding or maintaining one
- The **climate cue** did little, except to *decrease* Republican support for eliminating tax credits
- **Liberal Democrats** were unresponsive to both cues (H2 unsupported)
- **Education** did not moderate cue effects (H3, H4 unsupported), but independently lowers support among committed partisans on both sides
- Trump's energy actions are more likely to polarize opinion through their association with **Trump himself** than through their connection to **climate change**

Thank You!

Appendix

Descriptive Statistics

Variable	Range	Mean	SD
Tax Credits	1-5	2.26	1.28
Coal Open	1-5	2.48	1.25
Coal Leasing	1-5	2.39	1.28
Cancel Wind	1-5	2.09	1.25
Nuclear	1-5	2.97	1.33
Cons. Republican	0-1	0.40	0.49
Lib. Democrat	0-1	0.37	0.48
College	0-1	0.36	0.48

- Support for each action hovers near the midpoint of the 1–5 scale
 - Lowest: cancelling nearly complete wind projects (2.09)
 - Highest: shortening nuclear licensing (2.97)

Difference in Means by Cue Condition

Action	Control	Trump Cue	Climate Cue	Trump - Control	Climate - Control
Tax Credits	2.26	2.21	2.30	-0.06	+0.04
Coal Open	2.49	2.43	2.53	-0.06	+0.04
Coal Leasing	2.40	2.35	2.42	-0.05	+0.02
Cancel Wind	2.09	2.05	2.12	-0.05	+0.02
Nuclear	3.03	2.85	3.03	-0.18*	-0.00

Survey-weighted mean support (1-5) by cue condition, with mean differences from the control condition. Differences and tests from svyglm(support ~ trump.cue + climate.cue). † p<0.10, * p<0.05, ** p<0.01, *** p<0.001.

- The only significant raw difference: support for the nuclear regulatory changes is *lower* in the Trump condition than in the control

Weighted OLS Models: Main Effects

	Tax Credits	Coal Open	Coal Leasing	Cancel Wind	Nuclear
Trump Cue	-0.035	-0.074	-0.115	-0.037	-0.306†
	(0.135)	(0.141)	(0.146)	(0.115)	(0.166)
Climate Cue	0.320**	0.210†	0.090	0.169	-0.089
	(0.117)	(0.117)	(0.112)	(0.105)	(0.124)
Cons. Republican	1.119***	0.968***	0.933***	1.115***	0.555***
	(0.133)	(0.131)	(0.128)	(0.130)	(0.151)
Lib. Democrat	-0.491***	-0.649***	-0.617***	-0.328***	-0.376**
	(0.108)	(0.114)	(0.112)	(0.094)	(0.134)
College	0.178	0.086	0.041	0.280*	0.315**
	(0.114)	(0.113)	(0.109)	(0.113)	(0.114)
Intercept	1.983***	2.342***	2.267***	1.756***	2.911***
	(0.093)	(0.097)	(0.093)	(0.080)	(0.107)
Num.Obs.	3113	3113	3113	3113	3113
R2	0.330	0.368	0.358	0.314	0.163

† p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Weighted OLS Models: Interactions

	Tax Credits	Coal Open	Coal Leasing	Cancel Wind	Nuclear
Trump x ConRep	0.319	0.348†	0.456*	0.348†	0.506*
	(0.209)	(0.196)	(0.202)	(0.209)	(0.235)
Climate x ConRep	-0.442**	-0.239	-0.091	-0.212	0.142
	(0.167)	(0.156)	(0.158)	(0.164)	(0.176)
Trump x LibDem	-0.067	-0.068	-0.071	-0.130	-0.155
	(0.156)	(0.166)	(0.170)	(0.132)	(0.204)
Climate x LibDem	-0.238†	-0.170	-0.077	-0.147	0.098
	(0.136)	(0.138)	(0.132)	(0.120)	(0.153)
Trump x College	0.064	0.032	0.119	0.098	0.140
	(0.191)	(0.186)	(0.198)	(0.183)	(0.203)
College x ConRep	-0.230	-0.206	-0.169	-0.342*	-0.309†
	(0.162)	(0.149)	(0.152)	(0.167)	(0.165)
College x LibDem	-0.279*	-0.161	-0.172	-0.410***	-0.332*
	(0.130)	(0.132)	(0.126)	(0.124)	(0.143)
Trump x ConRep x College	-0.414	-0.096	-0.184	-0.401	-0.053
	(0.283)	(0.258)	(0.277)	(0.293)	(0.290)
Trump x LibDem x College	-0.011	-0.040	-0.104	0.026	0.029
	(0.213)	(0.214)	(0.222)	(0.199)	(0.249)
Num.Obs.	3113	3113	3113	3113	3113
R2	0.330	0.368	0.358	0.314	0.163
† p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001					

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